



THE PRINCIPLES AT WORK

SCRIPTURE PRACTICING ITS OWN PRINCIPLES — TWO EXAMPLES EACH



SUPPLEMENT TO *READING THE BIBLE WELL*

1

LET SCRIPTURE INTERPRET SCRIPTURE



- **Romans 4:1–8** — To prove what “credited as righteousness” means in Genesis 15:6, Paul sets it beside Psalm 32:1–2, letting David’s words about forgiveness apart from works clarify Moses’ words about Abraham’s faith.
- **Hebrews 4:1–11** — The author reads Psalm 95 (“Today, if you hear his voice”) alongside Genesis 2:2 and the Joshua story, and concludes from comparing the texts that a Sabbath rest still remains for God’s people.

2



READ EVERY PASSAGE IN LIGHT OF CHRIST

- **Luke 24:25–27** — On the Emmaus road, Jesus, “beginning with Moses and all the Prophets,” explains what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself — the founding charter of Christ-centered reading.
- **John 5:39–40, 46** — Jesus tells the experts that the very Scriptures they search testify about him: “Moses wrote about me.” Mastery of the text without arriving at Christ misses the point of the text.

3



KNOW THE PLACE IN THE ONE BIG STORY

- **Galatians 3:7–9, 16** — Paul reads the promise to Abraham as “the gospel announced in advance,” with Christ as the promised seed — one covenant storyline running from Genesis to the cross.
- **Revelation 21:1–22:5** — The Bible’s last chapters deliberately reopen its first: the tree of life, the curse removed, God dwelling with his people. The ending only makes sense as the resolution of Genesis 1–3.

4



SEEK THE AUTHOR’S INTENDED MEANING

- **Nehemiah 8:1–8** — Ezra’s Levites read the Law and “gave the meaning so that the people understood what was being read” — interpretation aimed at what the text actually says.
- **Jeremiah 29:4–14** — “Plans to prosper you” was written to exiles facing seventy years in Babylon. Read with its first audience in view, it becomes a word about God’s faithfulness through long waiting — a far richer comfort than a personal success slogan.

5



TAKE THE PLAIN SENSE

- **Galatians 4:21–31** — When Paul departs from the plain sense of the Hagar and Sarah story, he says so out loud: “these things are being taken figuratively.” The plain sense is the default; departures announce themselves.
- **Matthew 16:5–12** — The disciples take “the leaven of the Pharisees” literally and worry about bread; Jesus corrects them, and “then they understood” he meant teaching. Reading plainly means catching the metaphor the speaker intends — plain, not literalistic.

6



READ IN CONTEXT

- **Matthew 4:5–7** — Satan quotes Psalm 91 accurately but out of context; Jesus answers “it is also written,” refusing to let one verse override the whole counsel of God.
- **Philippians 4:10–13** — “I can do all things” sits inside a paragraph about contentment in hunger and plenty. The context turns a triumphalist motto back into what Paul meant: Christ’s strength for any circumstance.





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RESPECT THE GENRE



- **Proverbs 26:4–5** — “Answer a fool / do not answer a fool,” back to back. Proverbs are situational wisdom to be applied with discernment, not universal promises — and the book signals this itself.
- **Judges 21:25** — After chapters of escalating horror, the narrator’s verdict (“everyone did as they saw fit”) shows that biblical narrative often describes without prescribing. The story is a diagnosis, not a model.

8

LET THE CLEAR INTERPRET THE UNCLEAR



- **John 6:35, 51–63** — The startling “eat my flesh” saying is interpreted by the clear statements bracketing it: “whoever comes to me will never go hungry” and “the words I have spoken to you are Spirit and life.”
- **1 Corinthians 15** — Paul mentions baptism for the dead (v. 29) in passing, and no doctrine is built on it; the chapter anchors everything in the plainly stated gospel of verses 3–8 — holding the obscure loosely and the clear firmly.

9

READ WITH THE CHURCH, PAST AND PRESENT



- **Acts 15:1–21** — The circumcision question is not settled by one reader with one verse, but by apostles and elders together weighing testimony against the prophets: “the words of the prophets are in agreement with this.”
- **Acts 8:30–35** — “How can I understand unless someone explains it to me?” The Ethiopian’s honest question, and Philip’s guided reading of Isaiah 53, show that God ordinarily teaches us through teachers.

10

DEPEND ON THE HOLY SPIRIT



- **Luke 24:45** — Even after the resurrection, the disciples needed Jesus to “open their minds so they could understand the Scriptures.” Understanding is given, not merely achieved.
- **Psalms 119:18** — “Open my eyes that I may see wonderful things in your law” — the interpreter’s prayer, modeled inside Scripture itself. The psalmist has the text in hand and still asks for sight.

11

READ TO BE TRANSFORMED, FOR ALL OF LIFE



- **2 Kings 22–23** — Josiah hears the rediscovered Book of the Law, tears his robes, and reforms worship, politics, and public life across the nation. Hearing the Word remakes everything it touches.
- **Acts 2:37–42** — Peter’s Spirit-filled exposition of Scripture cuts hearers to the heart; the response is repentance, baptism, and a new shared life of teaching, fellowship, breaking bread, and prayer.



GOD’S WORD. WELL READ. WELL LIVED.

2 TIMOTHY 3:16–17